

Home › Living in Korea › Phone & SIM



Phone & SIM in Korea

How to get a Korean phone number, which carrier to choose, budget MVNO options, and the essential apps you need to live in Korea.



What You Need Before Getting a SIM

REQUIREMENTS

- **ARC (Alien Registration Card)** — required for post-paid plans (월정액). Most important document.
- **Passport** — required alongside ARC at carrier stores.
- **Unlocked phone** — make sure your phone is SIM-unlocked and supports Korean LTE bands (B1, B3, B5, B7). Most modern phones do.
- **Without ARC:** Tourist/prepaid SIMs are available at the airport — no ARC needed, but limited to data-only or short-term use.



Major Carriers (통신사)

**KT (케이티)**

Best Coverage

Korea's oldest and most reliable carrier. Best rural and

**SKT (에스케이텔레콤)**

Fastest Speed

Korea's largest carrier by subscribers. Fastest 5G speeds

**LG U+ (엘지유플러스)**

Good Value

Slightly cheaper plans than KT/SKT. Coverage is nearly as

building coverage. Good English customer service line.

in Seoul and major cities. T-world app is well-designed.

good. Good choice if you want to save ₩5,000–10,000/month.



Plan Comparison

PLAN TYPE	MONTHLY COST	DATA	BEST FOR
Tourist Prepaid SIM	₩15,000–30,000	2–10GB (no rollover)	Visitors, short stay, no ARC
MVNO Budget Plan	₩10,000–25,000	5–15GB	Long-stay, cost-conscious expats
Carrier Mid-tier	₩40,000–55,000	15–50GB + calls	Regular use, included calls
Carrier Unlimited	₩65,000–85,000	Unlimited (throttled after 100GB)	Heavy users, streaming
eSIM (International)	₩10,000–40,000	Varies	Travelers who want to keep home SIM

💡 **Best strategy for expats:** Go with an **MVNO (알뜰폰)** — they use the same KT/SKT/LG network towers but charge 40–60% less. Recommended MVNOs: **헬로모바일** (Hello Mobile), **U+알뜰모바일**, **KT M모바일**. Sign up online or at Emart/Homeplus.



How to Get Your Korean SIM — Step by Step

1

Get your ARC first

Without ARC, you can only get a prepaid tourist SIM. With ARC, you can sign a monthly plan and get a real Korean phone number (010-XXXX-XXXX).

2

Visit a carrier store or MVNO online

KT, SKT and LG U+ stores are everywhere — look for the brand logos. Or sign up online with an MVNO. Bring ARC + passport + bank card for the monthly bill setup.

3

Choose your plan

For most expats: 15–30GB/month is plenty for maps, social media, streaming. If you work from your phone, go unlimited. Ask about **공시지원금** (device subsidy) if buying a Korean phone.

4

Insert SIM and verify your number

Korean phone numbers start with 010. Once active, you'll need to verify your number with KakaoTalk, banking apps and Naver. This links everything together.

5

Set up essential apps

Install KakaoTalk first — it's how Koreans communicate. Then Naver Maps, KakaoTaxi, Coupang, Baemin and your bank app. See the full app list below.



10 Essential Apps for Living in Korea



KakaoTalk Messaging

How all Koreans communicate. Required for daily life — friends, landlords, employers all use it.



Naver Maps Navigation

Far better than Google Maps in Korea. Real-time transit, walking, cycling and driving routes.



Kakao T Transport

Taxi app + bike rental + public transport info. The Uber of Korea. Accepts foreign cards.



Baemin (배달의민족) Food Delivery

Korea's biggest food delivery app. Enormous selection, fast delivery, English interface available.



Coupang (쿠팡) Shopping / Delivery

Korea's Amazon. Next-day (often same-day) delivery on almost everything. Coupang Eats for food.



Toss (토스) Banking

Simplest Korean fintech app. Easy transfers, bill splitting, spending tracker. Everyone uses it.



Naver Search / Info

Korea's Google. Better for local restaurants, reviews and Korean-language information.



똑닥 (Ddocdoc) Healthcare

Book hospital and clinic appointments online. See wait times. Huge time saver vs walk-in queues.



Zigbang (직방) Housing

Best app to find apartments and one-rooms. Map-based search, photos and price history.



Wavve / TVING Entertainment

Korean streaming platforms for K-dramas and variety shows. Wavve has Korean subtitles, great for language learning.

Learn Korean to get more from these apps

Most Korean apps have limited English. Our 41-chapter course will help you navigate daily life.

[Try Free — Ch.1~5](#)[← Back to Living Guide](#)

[Home](#)[Living in Korea](#)[Banking](#)[Daily Life](#)[Contact](#)

© 2026 KR Guide. All rights reserved.